

about 3,600 words

The Palmerton Switch

by Douglass Burley Johnson

Annie Sabol had the sled rope wrapped twice around her right mitten and her brother on the far end of it, and the two of them were halfway up the dead mountain when the first tank car let go.

Nobody had told her yet that it had let go. What Annie knew was the cold in her knees through two pairs of jeans, the hemp rope burning through the wool, and the Flexible Flyer bumping along behind her with Danny riding it like a king because he was ten and she was sixteen and their mother had said the words "take your brother" in the voice that ends the conversation. It was the last Friday of January 1985. Snow had been coming down over Palmerton since supper, big soft flakes that fell straight because there was no wind, and the north face of Blue Mountain above the zinc works had turned into the best sledding hill in Carbon County.

Everybody in town called it the dead mountain. Seventy years of smoke from the zinc smelters had killed every tree on that slope and most of the dirt with them, and in daylight it looked like the bald gray back of an animal, all rock and rubble and burned stumps the color of

old pewter. Under snow it went smooth as a bedsheet, with no trees to hit and no brush to catch a runner. Kids from Palmerton and Aquashicola had been sneaking up there on snow nights since before their parents were born, and the plant guards mostly let them go as long as they stayed above the upper rail yard and kept off the cars.

Below them now sat a long string of black tank cars on the upper siding of the zinc company railroad, each one stenciled white along the belly. Annie's grandfather had walked that siding for thirty-one years as a switchman, and he had told her what the white letters meant when she was small enough to sit on his knee. Sulfuric acid. The smelter made it out of the smoke they used to let go into the sky, and the company shipped it out in cars like these to places that needed it. Dzedeo used to say a full acid car weighed more than a church and was meaner than the devil's cat if it ever got loose.

"Annie," Danny said. "Annie, the cars."

"I see them. We're above the yard. We're fine."

"No, they're going."

Annie stopped and turned around with the rope still around her mitten. Under the yard lights the snow came down in slow orange curtains, and through the curtains the black tank cars were easing forward along the upper siding the way a cow walks when she has decided to leave a field, slow and heavy and certain. No engine was coupled to them. No brakeman rode the end. The sound reached her a second after the sight, a low grinding of steel wheels on cold rail and a hollow knock as one coupler took up slack on the next.

"Somebody's moving them," she said.

"Nobody's on them," Danny said. "Annie. Nobody's on them."

Danny was right. Annie stood with snow landing on her eyelashes and counted twelve cars and not one person, and she watched the string clear the end of the upper siding and drop onto the long grade that ran down the hill toward town.

Dzedo had drawn that grade for her on the back of a church bulletin more times than she could count. The plant track came off the upper yard and fell along the base of the mountain for most of a mile, curving through the cut below the old east plant, and at the bottom it crossed the road below the ballfield and joined the main line along the Lehigh River. Halfway down the grade, at the place everybody still called the Palmerton switch, a short dead track branched off to the right and ran uphill into a bank of cinders as tall as a house. Dzedo called it the catch track. In the old days, he said, if a car ever broke away up top, a man at the switch threw it over and sent the car up the cinders, where it would dig in and stop short of town.

At nine o'clock the varsity game had let out. Annie had heard the horn from the gym on their way up the mountain. Half the parents in Palmerton would be sitting in their cars at that crossing right now, with the heaters running and the radio on, waiting for the gates.

"The switch," she said.

Danny already had his hand inside his coat. Out came the shoelace he wore around his neck, and the brass key on the end of it swung in the orange light. Dzedo had given him that key at Christmas, the old switch key with LNE stamped on the bow, and their mother had told him it was a toy now because nobody locked those switches anymore. Dzedo had looked at their mother over his glasses and said a switch is never a toy, and Danny had slept with the key under his pillow every night since.

"They still lock it," Danny said. "Dzedo checks. He walks down there Sundays and checks."

Annie looked at the grade and then at the sled.

A hundred times she had been down that slope, and never at night past the third fence post, because past the third fence post the mountain steepened into a long chute of bare rock under the snow that ran straight down to the cut above the switch. Big kids called it the Elevator. Pete Hornick had broken his arm on it in seventh grade and bragged about it for two years.

"Get on," she said. "Lie flat. Hold the sides and don't let go of the sides for anything."

"Are we going to the switch?"

"We're going to the switch."

Danny lay down on the Flyer and gripped the wooden rails with both mittens. Annie threw herself on top of him, belly to his back, and caught the steering bar with her hands, and she dug her boot toes in and shoved. Over the lip they went, and the mountain fell out from under them.

Never in her life had Annie gone so fast. The runners hissed and then roared. Snow came up off the front of the sled in a white sheet that hit her face like thrown sand, and every bump in the buried rock slammed through the slats into her ribs. Danny was yelling under her, and the yell came up through his back into her chest more than it came through the air. Off to their left, through the falling snow and the yard lights, the tank cars ran down the grade beside them, black and enormous, gaining speed on every rail length, and the sound they made had become a steady rolling thunder that came up through the ground and into the sled.

They passed the first fence post and the second. At the third the mountain tipped down into the Elevator and the sled left the snow for a long second and came down so hard her teeth clacked on her tongue, and her mouth filled with the taste of blood. Annie pulled the steering bar

left to stay out of the stumps and the Flyer answered her, and she thought very clearly that if she lived she would never be mean to Danny again for as long as she lived.

The first tank car drew even with them and then pulled ahead.

"Annie," Danny yelled. "Annie, we're losing."

"I know."

"Pray. Dzedo says pray."

"You pray," she said. "I'm steering."

Danny did. Annie heard him do it with his face an inch from the snow, the prayer Dzedo prayed at every meal and every funeral and every time the old Buick wouldn't start, the one he said the monks used to say with every breath. "Lord Jesus Christ, Son of God, have mercy on us. Lord Jesus Christ, Son of God, have mercy on us." Danny said it over and over, loud, the way a ten-year-old says the Pledge, and Annie steered and kept her own mouth shut, because she was sixteen and had stopped praying out loud in front of people sometime around eighth grade, and because a part of her she did not like was embarrassed even here, even now, with the cars running away beside her in the dark.

At the bottom the chute ended in a long apron of drifted snow above the cut. The sled hit the drift and plowed through it and slewed sideways and threw them both off into powder up to their waists. Annie came up spitting snow. Thirty yards down the bank stood the Palmerton switch, beside the rail, with its round red target on top of the stand and its long iron lever lying flat against the ties, padlocked to the stand with a lock gone white with frost.

Up the grade, maybe a quarter mile and coming, the lead tank car rounded the curve out of the old east plant cut with snow boiling off its wheels.

They ran. Annie half ran and half fell down the bank with Danny's hand in her mitten, and they hit the ballast at the switch stand together, and Danny pulled the shoelace over his head so fast it knocked his hat off. Annie took the key. Her mittens were too thick, so she tore the right one off with her teeth, and the cold bit into her bare fingers like a dog. On the second try she got the key into the lock and turned it, and it did not turn.

"It's froze," she said. "It's frozen solid."

"Breathe on it," Danny said. "Dzedo breathes on it."

Annie put her mouth down to the lock and breathed on it, hot and hard, and tried the key, and breathed again. Down the grade toward them came the thunder of the cars, and the rail beside her boots began to sing. By now the lead car was plain to see, the white letters on its belly, the frost on its dome. The lock would not give, and her fingers would not close right anymore. Danny had his hands on top of hers and was saying the prayer again, very fast now, the words running together into one long word, and Annie knew with her whole body that they were not going to make it, that there was not enough time in the world for a frozen lock and a stuck lever and a girl's bare hand.

So she prayed. It came up out of her chest the way the yell had come out of Danny on the mountain, plain words of her own that nobody had ever taught her. "Jesus," she said, out loud, with her mouth against the frozen lock, "I need more time. Please. I need more time than this."

Every flake of snow in the air stopped where it was.

Annie lifted her head. Between her and the yard lights the snow hung in the air, millions of flakes, still as stars, close enough to touch. The thunder of the cars had stretched into one long low note like an organ holding the last chord of a hymn, and the note did not change. A hundred yards up the grade sat the lead tank car, still rolling and not moving, snow frozen in a spray off

its front wheels like a photograph of a wave. Beside her Danny knelt with his mouth open on the word "mercy" and a flake caught on his eyelashes, and he did not blink, and he did not breathe.

"Danny," she said. He did not answer.

Light came down the track toward her.

It came from the downhill side, from town, a yellow swinging light at about the height of a man's hip, and it moved through the hung snow without disturbing a flake. Behind it walked a man. Annie had never seen a bigger one. He stood taller than the switch stand by a full head, in a long canvas railroad coat buttoned to the throat and a cap with a short brim, and he carried an old kerosene lantern with a wire bail and a red globe the way Dzedo carried his lunch pail, easy and ordinary. His boots crunched on the ballast. Every other sound in the world held still on its one long note, and his boots crunched.

On the other side of the switch stand the man stopped and held the lantern up so its light fell on the lock and her hands.

He never touched the lock, and he never touched Annie. Over the lantern he looked at her with a face she could never afterward describe except to say that it was kind the way a doctor is kind before he sets a bone, and he waited.

Annie understood that he was not going to throw the switch for her. It came to her the way cold water comes to a body that steps into it. The lantern was for seeing by. The time was the time she had asked for. The hands were hers.

In the lantern light Annie breathed on the lock again. Breathing came easier now, and her breath went out warm and white and hung in the air with the snow, and when she turned the key the lock gave with a small sound like a knuckle cracking. Annie worked the shackle out of the hasp and dropped the lock in the snow. Then Annie bent and took the lever handle in both bare

hands. Dzedo had shown her when she was eight, standing behind her with his big hands over her small ones, how you set your feet wide and lift the handle up off the ties and then lean the whole of your body across it and walk it over in a half circle until it lies down on the other side and the points move. It had been stiff then on a summer afternoon. Tonight the cold had frozen it into the stand.

Annie lifted, and the handle stayed down.

Annie set her feet wider in the ballast and lifted again with her legs and her back and every muscle she owned, and the iron handle tore the skin off the inside of her palms where it stuck, and she did not let go. "Jesus," she said through her teeth. "Jesus. Jesus." The handle came up off the ties an inch, then six inches, then all the way up, and she got her shoulder under it and leaned her body across it the way Dzedo had shown her and walked it over. Ice cracked in the points. Down at the rail the long steel point blades slid across in the lantern light with a scraping groan and closed against the other rail, and the round red target on top of the stand turned on its spindle and showed her the green side.

Annie laid the lever down and stood up with her hands bleeding.

The man with the lantern looked at the green target and then at her, and he lowered the lantern to his side. Annie heard him speak, or thought she heard him, one word in a voice like a big engine idling a long way off, and the word was "Good." Then he turned and walked back toward town the way he had come, through the hung snow, and the yellow light went down the track and grew small and went out.

Then the snow fell.

All of it came down at once, and the long organ note broke apart into thunder, and Danny finished the word "mercy" and blinked and grabbed her coat. The lead tank car came off the

grade at them in a roar. Annie threw herself and Danny backward into the drift beside the ballast, and the car hit the switch points and swung right onto the catch track, and the next car followed it, and the next, twelve black cars full of acid bucking and screaming off the main grade one after another and running uphill onto the dead track toward the cinder bank.

Nose first the lead car buried itself in the cinders like a plow. Behind it the whole string piled in, coupler on coupler, with a sound that stayed in Annie's teeth for a week. Cinders and snow went up in a black and white cloud over the end of the track. Then one by one the cars stopped knocking, and the cloud came down, and the only sound left was the hiss of hot brake shoes melting the snow that fell on them.

Not one car had tipped, and not one had cracked.

Danny was crying with his face against her coat. "You stopped it," he said. "Annie, the snow stopped. Did you see the snow stop?"

"I saw it."

"Did you see the man?"

Annie let that one go by. Holding him, she looked down the track toward town where the lantern had gone out, and she saw the long empty rails shining under the yard lights, and on the ballast beside the switch stand she saw her own boot prints and Danny's and the lock lying open in the snow. No other track marked the snow. No big boot prints went toward town.

A minute later the plant whistle started blowing, and then the fire siren down at the borough building, and inside ten minutes there were men with flashlights all over the grade. A yard foreman named Gus Remaley found them sitting on the switch stand with Annie's bare hands stuck in Danny's armpits for warmth. Gus looked at the green target and the open lock and the key on the shoelace, and he looked at the twelve cars buried in the cinders, and he said a

word Annie's mother did not allow in the house. Then he took his own gloves off and put them on her hands.

"Who threw this," he said.

"I did," Annie said.

"You threw this. Frozen. By yourself."

"Yes sir."

Gus did not believe her and he did not argue. Later the company men would say the handbrakes on the string had never been set right by the afternoon crew and the cold had let the slack run out, and the newspaper in Allentown would print a short piece on page six about an alert local teenager and a runaway string of cars, and nobody would ever ask her about the snow.

Dzedo was waiting up in the kitchen when the foreman's truck dropped them at the house on Columbia Avenue. At the table in his undershirt he sat with his coffee and his rosary and the radio scanner going, and he had heard the whole thing come over the scanner from the first siren. One look at Annie's hands wrapped in the foreman's gloves and at Danny's wet face, and he did not ask what happened. Instead Dzedo got up and filled the dishpan with cool water and set her hands in it one at a time and held them there.

"You threw it," he said.

"Yes."

"The handle was froze."

"Yes."

Dzedo kept his hands on her wrists in the water. After a while he asked, very quietly, so their mother upstairs would not hear, "Did he hold the lantern for you?"

Annie looked up at him.

"Nineteen fifty-one," Dzedo said. "February. A coal car off the upper yard and me twenty-two years old at that same switch with my hands froze to it. Big fellow. Red globe on the lantern. He held it so I could see the lock." Dzedo let go of her wrists and patted the back of one of her hands in the water, very gently, the way he patted the dog. "He doesn't throw it for you. You know that now."

"I know," Annie said.

Annie Sabol is fifty-seven now and lives in a house on the hill in Palmerton where she can see Blue Mountain from her kitchen window. Long ago the zinc company shut down. For twenty years the government spread seed and lime and sludge across the dead mountain, and the mountain came back. In summer it is green now, grass and little birches and sumac turning red in October, and people walk the trails up there with their dogs and binoculars and no idea it was ever bare. Both the catch track and the Palmerton switch stand are gone. Dzedo has been gone since 1997, and Danny is a deacon now and still wears the brass key on a shoelace under his shirt on Sundays.

Annie prays out loud now. In the grocery store and the car and at the bedside of her grandchildren she prays, plain and short and not embarrassed, and when one of them asks her why, she shows them the white scars across the inside of both palms where the iron took the skin, and she tells them about the night she asked for more time and got it.

Annie has never told any of them that the snow stopped. She keeps that one. On snow nights with no wind, when the flakes come down straight and slow past the kitchen window, she stands at the glass with her hands around a cup of coffee and watches the green mountain go white, and she waits to see whether a yellow light will come walking down out of the dark toward town.

It never has. She still looks.

END